

Section A — Chapter 9

Independence and Partition of India

Class 10 - Total History & Civics Solutions

Multiple Choice Questions

Question 1

Which of the following international events forced Britain to consider handing over the governance of India to Indians?

1. End of Fascism
2. Rise of Communism
3. World War II
4. Rise of USA as a superpower

Answer

World War II

Question 2

Who among the following was NOT a part of the Cabinet Mission?

1. Penthic Lawrence
2. Sir Stafford Cripps
3. A.V. Alexander
4. Lord Linlithgow.

Answer

Lord Linlithgow

Question 3

Arrange the following events in chronological order

- (i) End of World War

(ii) Attlee's Announcement

(iii) Mountbatten Plan

(iv) Cabinet Mission

1. (i), (ii), (iii) and (iv)
2. (i), (iv), (ii), and (iii)
3. (i), (iv), (iii) and (ii)
4. (i), (iii), (ii) and (iv)

Answer

(i), (iv), (ii), and (iii)

Question 4

Why was the Cabinet Mission sent to India in 1946?

1. To facilitate transfer of power to Indians
2. To facilitate the Partition of the country
3. To facilitate the division of resources between Provinces and Princely States.
4. To facilitate the drawing up of the Constitution for each Dominion.

Answer

To facilitate transfer of power to Indians

Question 5

Group A : United Provinces :: Group B :

1. Baluchistan
2. Punjab
3. Delhi
4. Bihar

Answer

Punjab

Question 6

Which of the following was NOT proposed by the Cabinet Mission?

1. Federal Union of British Provinces
2. Formation of a Constituent Assembly
3. British Provinces to be divided on linguistic basis
4. Union government would control communication

Answer

British Provinces to be divided on linguistic basis

Question 7

Why did the Muslim League accept the Cabinet Mission Plan?

1. Its demand for a separate nation was fulfilled.
2. It felt that grouping of Muslim majority Provinces was a step towards a separate dominion.
3. It felt that its claim to nominate Muslim members to the Executive Council was supported.
4. None of the above.

Answer

It felt that grouping of Muslim majority Provinces was a step towards a separate dominion.

Question 8

Which of the following is incorrect about the formation of a Constituent Assembly according to the Cabinet Mission Plan?

1. Members to be directly elected by the people of India
2. Members to be elected by Provincial Legislative Assemblies
3. 296 members from the Provinces and 93 from princely states
4. Complete freedom to frame the Constitution of the Indian Union.

Answer

Members to be directly elected by the people of India

Question 9

Which of the following forced the British government to send Lord Mountbatten?

1. Communal riots
2. Labour Unrest

3. Congress-League deadlock
4. All of the above

Answer

All of the above

Question 10

The Muslim League put forth a demand which had tragic consequences. What was the demand? What did it result in ?

1. The demand for a separate Muslim-dominated Pakistan. It resulted in the Partition of country.
2. The demand for separate electorate for Muslims. It resulted in the Partition of India.
3. The demand for Muslim leadership of the country. It resulted in the formation of Pakistan.
4. The demand to have a Governor General of a dominion. It resulted in the Partition of the country.

Answer

The demand for a separate Muslim-dominated Pakistan. It resulted in the Partition of country.

Question 11

According to Indian Independence Act, a plebiscite would be held in

1. Bihar
2. Sylhet
3. Princely states
4. Central provinces

Answer

Sylhet

Question 12

According to Mountbatten Plan which is incorrect regarding the status of Princely States?

1. They will become independent
2. All treaties would end.
3. Plebiscite will be held

4. Freedom to associate with any dominion

Answer

Plebiscite will be held

Question 13

The Indian Independence Act provided for division of which state if so desired by the people?

1. Jammu and Kashmir
2. Punjab and Bengal
3. Bihar and Orissa (Odisha)
4. Bombay and Madras

Answer

Punjab and Bengal

Question 14

Which of the following provisions regarding the Constituent Assemblies is/are correct?

1. Act as Central Legislatures in each dominion
2. Full powers to make laws for their dominion
3. Act as sovereign bodies for legislative purpose
4. All of the above

Answer

All of the above

Question 15

Who had the power to bring India Independence Act into operation?

1. The Secretary of State for India
2. The Governor General
3. The British Prime Minister
4. None of the above.

Answer

The British Prime Minister

Short Answer Questions

Question 1

State two important reasons that prompted the British to withdraw from India.

Answer

Two important reasons that prompted the British to withdraw from India were-

1. Even though Britain was on the winning side of the War, its economic and military power was shattered. It would take Britain years to rehabilitate itself.
2. The Government could not any longer rely on Indians for its civil administration or on the armed forces for suppression of the national movement. The INA had shown that patriotic ideas had entered the ranks of the Indian army, the chief instrument of British rule in India.

Question 2

How did the outcome of the Second World War help India's demand for self-government?

Answer

The outcome of the Second World War helped India's demand for self-government in the following ways-

1. The World War changed the balance of power in the world. The United States of America and the Soviet Union, emerged from the War as the two big powers. Both supported India's demand for freedom.
2. Even though Britain was on the winning side of the War, its economic and military power was shattered. It would take Britain years to rehabilitate itself.
3. There was a change of government in Britain. The Conservatives were replaced by the Labour Party, many of them supported the Congress demands.
4. The British soldiers were weary of the War. Having fought and shed their blood for six years, they had no desire to spend many more years away from home suppressing the Indian people's struggle for freedom.

Question 3

What was the implication of the Group B States proposed by the Cabinet Mission Plan?

Answer

According to the Cabinet Mission Plan, Group B would include three Muslim majority provinces-

1. Punjab
2. North West Frontier Province (NWFP)
3. Sind

Question 4

What was mentioned in the Cabinet Mission Plan regarding Provincial Autonomy?

Answer

The Cabinet Mission Plan proposed that the Provinces would enjoy full autonomy for all subjects other than the Union subjects.

Question 5

What arguments did the Cabinet Mission give to reject Jinnah's proposal of Pakistan?

Answer

Muslim League's demand for Pakistan was rejected by the Cabinet Mission for the following reasons:

1. The establishment of Pakistan would not solve the problem of communal minorities because the number of Muslims in the remaining part of British India and the number of non-Muslims in Pakistan would be sizeable.
2. There was no justification for including within Pakistan, the non-Muslim districts of Bengal, Assam and the Punjab.
3. The armed forces, transportation as well as the postal and telegraph system had been built for India as a whole and the partition would create many problems.
4. The Princely States would find it difficult to decide which Union to join.
5. The two halves of the proposed Pakistan State would be separated by some seven hundred miles and interaction between them would be difficult.

Question 6

What was said in the Cabinet Mission Plan about the division of power between the Federal Government and the Provinces?

Answer

The Cabinet Mission proposed a two-tier federal plan which was expected to maintain national unity while conceding the largest measure of regional autonomy.

1. There was to be a federal union of the British Provinces and the Princely States. The Union Government (Central Government) should deal with the following Subjects:

- i. Foreign Affairs
- ii. Defence
- iii. Communication

The Union Government Should have the power to raise the finances required for the above mentioned subjects. The Union would have its own executive and legislature composed of members elected by all Provinces.

- 2. The Provinces would enjoy full autonomy for all subjects other than the Union subjects.

Question 7

Why did the Muslim League accept Cabinet Mission proposals?

Answer

The Muslim League accepted the Cabinet Mission proposals in its entirety in June 1946 because it felt that the grouping of Muslim majority Provinces in a way meant the formation of Pakistan. The League asked Wavell, the Viceroy, to constitute an Interim Government.

Question 8

What was the reaction of the Congress to the Cabinet Mission Plan?

Answer

The Congress accepted the proposals of the Cabinet Mission Plan with reservations. It accepted only that part of the scheme which dealt with the Constitution making. It considered the Constituent Assembly as a sovereign body for drafting the Constitution. The Congress wanted the grouping of the Provinces as optional and not compulsory.

The Congress rejected the Viceroy's offer to form an Interim Government because of its limited status and powers and also because the principle of parity with Muslim League was not acceptable to it. It was also opposed to the League's claim that it alone had the right to nominate all the Muslim members to the Executive Council.

Question 9

Who was elected as the President of the Constituent Assembly in 1946? Name the last Viceroy of India. State one of his proposals with regard to the Princely States.

Answer

Dr. Rajendra Prasad was elected as the President of the Constituent Assembly in 1946.

Lord Mountbatten was the last Viceroy of India.

As regards the Princely States, the Mountbatten Plan stated that the treaties with them would come to an end. They would be free to associate themselves with either of the Dominions or to remain independent.

Question 10

What was the most important but tragic provision of the Mountbatten Plan?

Answer

The most important but tragic provision of the Mountbatten Plan was the transfer of power without any delay and partition of the country into two dominions.

Question 11

To whom was the power to be transferred according to the Mountbatten Plan?

Answer

According to the Mountbatten Plan the transfer of power in India could be on the basis of the partition of the country. Power would be transferred to one whole or more States.

Question 12

Mention any two reasons why the Congress finally accepted the Partition of India.

Answer

The Congress finally accepted the Partition of India because of the following reasons-

1. The large-scale communal riots that engulfed the whole country convinced all that the only solution to the communal problem lay in the Partition of India.
2. The League had joined the Interim Government to obstruct and not to cooperate. Experience of working with the League had convinced the Congress that it could not have a joint administration with the League.

Question 13

Mention any two provisions of the Indian Independence Act, 1947.

Answer

Two provisions of the Indian Independence Act, 1947 were-

1. India would be partitioned and two independent Dominions — India and Pakistan — would be created from August 15, 1947. The Act provided legislative supremacy of both the Dominions. The territories of the two Dominions were divided in such terms that

Pakistan would comprise Sindh, British Baluchistan, North West Frontier Province, the West Punjab and East Bengal. India was to comprise all the remaining territories included in the British India. The exact boundaries of the Dominions would be determined by a Boundary Commission.

2. There would be a Governor-General who would be appointed by the British King on the advice of the Cabinet of the concerned Dominion. This arrangement would work till the framing of the Constitutions.

Question 14

What did the Indian Independence Act 1947 state about:

- (i) Bengal and Punjab
- (ii) North West Frontier Province
- (iii) Sylhet District of Assam?

Answer

With regards to the following points, Indian Independence Act, 1947 stated the following-

1. **Bengal and Punjab** — Both Bengal and Punjab would be divided if so desired by the people. The Provincial Assemblies of the two parts would meet separately representing Hindu majority districts and Muslim majority districts and would decide through a majority vote whether they wanted the division of the province or not.
2. **North West Frontier Province** — A plebiscite would be held in North West Frontier Province (NWFP) to determine whether they would like to join Pakistan or India.
3. **Sylhet District of Assam** — A plebiscite would be held in Sylhet district (Muslim majority area) in East Bengal to determine whether they would like to join Pakistan or India.

Question 15

Name the first Governor-General of independent India and the first Indian Governor-General of India.

Answer

The first Governor-General of independent India was Lord Mountbatten.

The first Indian Governor-General of India was C. Rajagopalachari.

Structured Questions

Question 1

The Cabinet Mission Plan proposed a two-tiered federal union of British Provinces and Princely States. With reference to this describe the following:

- (a) Name the persons who constituted the Cabinet Mission. What was the purpose of sending the Cabinet Mission to India in 1946?
- (b) The federal structure proposed by the Cabinet Mission Plan.
- (c) The option given to the Princely States.

Answer

(a) The Cabinet Mission consisted of three cabinet members:

1. Pethic Lawrence, the Secretary of State
2. Sir Stafford Cripps, President of the Board of Trade
3. A.V. Alexander, the First Lord of Admiralty

The purpose of sending the Cabinet Mission to India in 1946 was to help the Indian leaders decide the form of government that would suit them after the transfer of power.

(b) The Cabinet Mission proposed a two-tier federal plan which was expected to maintain national unity while conceding the largest measure of regional autonomy.

1. There was to be a federal union of the British Provinces and the Princely States. The Union Government (Central Government) should deal with the following Subjects:
 - i. Foreign Affairs
 - ii. Defence
 - iii. CommunicationThe Union Government should have the power to raise the finances required for the above mentioned subjects. The Union would have its own executive and legislature composed of members elected by all Provinces.
2. The Provinces would enjoy full autonomy for all subjects other than the Union subjects.

(c) According to the Cabinet Mission plan, the Provinces would enjoy full autonomy for all subjects other than the Union subjects.

1. The British Provinces would be divided into three groups.
2. Each group could determine the provincial subjects to be taken in common.
3. A province could opt out of any group and join another by a majority of votes.

Question 2

The attempt of the British to pacify the Congress and the Muslim League was clearly visible in the Cabinet Mission proposals but in reality neither could be pleased. With reference to this, explain:

(a) Any three proposals of the Cabinet Mission.

(b) The reasons for the Muslim League's acceptance and later rejection of the Cabinet Mission Plan.

(c) Why did the Congress refuse to participate in the formation of the Interim Government under the Cabinet Mission Plan?

Answer

(a) Three proposals of the Cabinet Mission were-

1. **Formation of a Constituent Assembly** — A Constituent Assembly would be set up to frame the new Constitution of the Indian Union. The composition of the 389 member Constituent Assembly would be as under:
 - (i) 296 members to be elected from the British Provinces.
 - (ii) 93 members to be elected from the Princely States.The members of the Constituent Assembly would be elected by the Provincial Legislative Assemblies.
2. **Representation of Minorities** — Separate representation was to be given to Muslims and Sikhs.
3. **Formation of an Interim Government** — An Interim Government would be formed at the Centre with 14 members. For the time being, the Viceroy would reconstitute his Executive Council consisting of representatives of all communities.

(b) The Muslim League accepted the Cabinet Mission proposals in its entirety in June 1946 because it felt that the grouping of Muslim majority Provinces in a way meant the formation of Pakistan. The League asked Wavell, the Viceroy, to constitute an Interim Government.

The Muslim League rejected the Cabinet Mission Plan as-

1. Elections to the Constituent Assembly were held in July 1946, in which the Congress obtained two-third majority.
2. The League feared that it would be out-voted in the Assembly. It also feared that the British withdrawal from India would mean transfer of power to Hindus, who were in a majority in India.
3. The League's nominees were not prepared to work under Nehru's leadership. They openly rejected the idea of collective responsibility.

(c) The Congress rejected the Viceroy's offer to form an Interim Government because of its limited status and powers and also because the principle of parity with Muslim League was not

acceptable to it. It was also opposed to the League's claim that it alone had the right to nominate all the Muslim members to the Executive Council.

Picture Study

Question 1

In the historic photograph, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, is being sworn in as Prime Minister of free India. In this context answer the following:



- (a) Mention the Provisions of the Indian Independence Act of 1947 regarding the Constituent Assembly.
- (b) Discuss three basic reasons why the Cabinet Mission Plan rejected the demand for Pakistan.
- (c) Mention the areas where plebiscites were to be held. What was the position of His Majesty's government in the new set-up in India?

Answer

(a) The provisions of the Indian Independence Act of 1947 regarding the Constituent Assembly were that the Constituent Assemblies of both the dominions were to act as the Central Legislatures and would have full powers to make laws for their respective Dominion. They would act as sovereign bodies for legislative purposes.

(b) Three basic reasons because of which the Cabinet Mission Plan rejected the demand for Pakistan were-

1. The establishment of Pakistan would not solve the problem of communal minorities because the number of Muslims in the remaining part of British India and the number of non-Muslims in Pakistan would be sizeable.

2. There was no justification for including within Pakistan, the non-Muslim districts of Bengal, Assam and Punjab.
3. The armed forces, transportation as well as the postal and telegraph system had been built for India as a whole and the partition would create many problems.

(c) Plebiscites were to be held in North West Frontier Province (NWFP) as well as in Sylhet district (Muslim majority area) in East Bengal to determine whether they would like to join Pakistan or India.

One of the provisions of the Indian Independence Act of 1947 was the end of jurisdiction of the British Parliament.

1. The legislative authority of the British Parliament would cease from August 15, 1947.
2. The title of the 'Emperor of India' was dropped from the royal style.
3. Till the new Constitution was framed, each of the Dominions and all the Provinces were to be governed in accordance with the Act of 1935.
4. The Governor-General was given the powers to modify or adopt the Government of India Act 1935 by March 31, 1948.
5. The right of the King to veto laws was given up. This right was given to the Governor-General.

Question 2

With reference to the picture given below answer the questions that follow:



- (a) Identify the person in the picture. State any two features of the Plan devised by him.
- (b) How did he plan to solve the communal problem existing in India?
- (c) Why did the Congress accept the Plan? State three reasons to justify its acceptance.

Answer

- (a)** The person shown in the picture is Lord Mountbatten.

Two features of the Plan devised by Lord Mountbatten were:

1. **Partition** — The country would be divided into two Dominions, i.e., India and Pakistan.
2. **A Boundary Commission** — A Boundary Commission would be created to settle the boundaries of the two Dominions in case partition was decided upon.

- (b)** Lord Mountbatten found that it was difficult to solve the deadlock between the Congress and the Muslim League.

1. He realised that the Cabinet Mission Plan was unworkable and a partition of India was inevitable.
2. He, therefore, sought to effect the transfer of power without any delay.
3. Mountbatten put his plan for the partition of India before the 'big seven' leaders — Nehru, Patel, Kripalani, Jinnah, Liaquat, Nishtar and Baldev Singh.
4. The Congress accepted the Plan and Jinnah undertook to do his utmost to make the Plan work.
5. The Plan was announced on June 3, 1947.
6. The country would be divided into two Dominions, i.e. India and Pakistan.

- (c)** The Congress accepted the Mountbatten Plan because of the following reasons-

1. The large-scale communal riots that engulfed the whole country convinced all that the only solution to the communal problem lay in the Partition of India.
2. The League had joined the Interim Government to obstruct and not to cooperate. Experience of working with the League had convinced the Congress that it could not have a joint administration with the League.
3. The only alternative to Partition was a Federation with a weak Centre. A smaller India with a strong central authority was better than a bigger State with weak Centre.

Thinking Skills

Question 1

A number of Acts were passed by the British to pacify the demands of the Indians relating to the Government of India. But the Independence Act, 1947 is considered as a unique piece of legislation. Why is it so? Give reasons to support your answer.

Answer

The Independence Act, 1947 is a unique piece of legislation because never before has such a large portion of the world population achieved complete independence through legislation. The Act marked the end of the British rule in India. The Dominions of India and Pakistan came into existence on August 15, 1947.

Question 2

Do you think that the All-India Congress Party had no alternative but to accept the Mountbatten Plan? Support your answer with examples.

Answer

Yes, the All-India Congress Party had no alternative but to accept the Mountbatten Plan because of the following reasons —

1. The large-scale communal riots that engulfed the whole country convinced all that the only solution to the communal problem lay in the Partition of India.
2. The League had joined the Interim Government to obstruct and not to cooperate. Experience of working with the League had convinced the Congress that it could not have a joint administration with the League.
3. The only alternative to Partition was a Federation with a weak Centre. A smaller India with a strong central authority was better than a bigger State with weak Centre.
4. Any further continuation of British rule would mean a greater calamity for India. The British were instigating the rulers of the Indian States to remain independent. Hence, partition was the price for immediate independence.
5. The leaders felt that further delay in the transfer of power could find India in the midst of a Civil War.
6. The leaders felt that Partition would rid the Constitution of separate electorates and other undemocratic procedures. India could then evolve as a truly secular and democratic polity.